

## FASHION ICON

# ELEANOR OF AQUITAINE

**E**leanor of Aquitaine (c.1124–1204) is one of the most important and well-known figures of the Middle Ages, due to her huge influence on the cultural life of the time. Born into the ruling family of the Duchy of Aquitaine, a large province that covered most of south-western France, this cultured, sophisticated, and most eligible heiress in Europe had an extraordinary zest for life. At 15 she married the future King Louis VII of France and moved to Paris. Used to luxury and splendour, Eleanor found the city bleak and grey. She immediately set about transforming Paris into a centre of art and beauty. With her strong sense of style, she introduced new fashions, fabrics, and etiquette from the more sophisticated south. Nobles from Aquitaine had a reputation for being fashion conscious, and the new queen shocked Louis' courtiers with her jewels, kohl, and rouge. Chronicler Bernard of Clairvaux remarked that her gowns were "not so much adorned as loaded down with gold, silver, and precious stones". She was said to be tall and extremely beautiful and continued to enchant men across the known world into her old age.

### Setting the trend

Under her influence, women's clothing became increasingly elaborate. The *bliaut*, a long overgown, was a new trend. In Eleanor's reign it grew tighter around the bodice, fitting snugly down to the hips, and was worn with a decorative belt or girdle. The bodice was split down either side from underarm to hip and fitted with ribbons, which could be tied to tighten the fabric across the body.

The skirt was cut wide, falling in light folds and pleats down to the feet. This emphasized the conspicuous use of rich fabrics. Silk from the Middle East was readily available throughout Europe and used extensively by the royal court.

In a palette of blues, greys, burgundies, and earth tones, the silk was highly embellished and heavily embroidered in costly metallic threads. The garments' sumptuous flow outraged church fathers: Bernard of Clairvaux complained about the ladies at court who "drag after them trains of precious material that makes a cloud of dust".

Bliaut sleeves also drew attention; they were tight from shoulder to elbow, then flared out into enormous cuffs long enough to drag on the ground. Sleeves were knotted to shorten them and to make them more manageable.

### Impact abroad

A formidable woman, Eleanor accompanied her husband in 1147 on the Second Crusade (1145–1149), travelling to Constantinople (modern Istanbul) and Jerusalem. She took chests of the finest clothing with her so she might appear as a sophisticated Provençal queen instead of a Frankish rustic. She cut a dashing figure. The Greek chronicler Niketas Choniates noted Eleanor's ride into Byzantium: "...even women travelled in the ranks of the crusaders, boldly sitting astride in their saddles as men do...At the head of these was one in particular, richly dressed, who because of the gold embroidery on the hem of her dress, was nicknamed *Chrysopous* [Golden Foot]."

Eleanor was granted an annulment of her marriage to Louis in 1152 and went on to marry Henry of Anjou as a love match. In 1154 he became King of England. As in Paris, Eleanor began to turn primitive England into an illustrious court, introducing art, make-up, romance, and poetry under the influence of her glamorous personality. Wherever she went, Eleanor challenged tradition, developing the style and sophistication, romance, and chivalry for which the medieval period became famous.

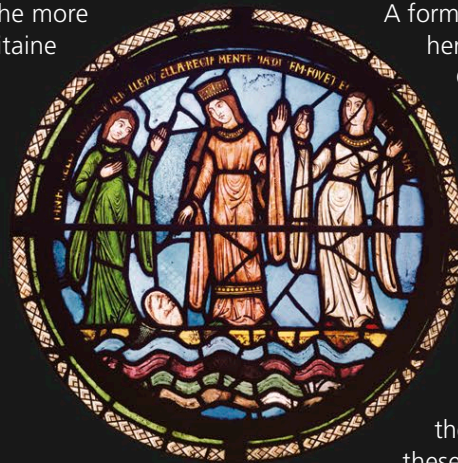


### △ INTERNATIONAL INFLUENCES

In this effigy from Fontevraud Abbey, the queen's dress was originally covered with diagonal bars of gold, representing an expensive Eastern silk. She wears the *barbette* and is reading a book – a literate woman in illiterate times.

### ◁ NOBLE COLOURS

Wealthy noblewomen wear the *bliaut* with extravagant sleeves in this 12th-century stained-glass window in the Abbey of Saint-Denis, France. Courtly romances describe how the gowns could be open at the side to reveal delicate underwear.

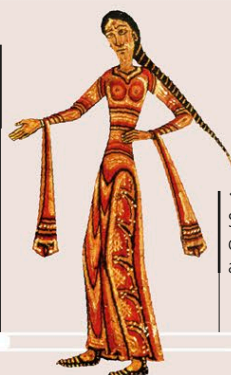


### TIMELINE

1137 Marries Louis and becomes Queen of France, bringing sophistication to the Paris court

1140s ▷ Popularizes the *bliaut* and other long overgowns with trailing sleeves and hems

1140s Patronizes the troubadour poets of her native court. In turn, they praise her "lovely eyes and noble countenance"



1147 Takes part in the Second Crusade. Her cloaks are sumptuous and heavily embroidered

1154 Becomes Queen of England, and introduces new style and standards of living to the English court – drinking wine instead of beer, and bringing in costly silks and love poets



◁ 1167 Popularizes long plaited hair. Returns to France, after being estranged from Henry II, and cultivates a court in Poitiers unmatched by any in Europe for its cultural influence

1173 Is imprisoned for 16 years after taking part in a revolt against Henry II